and bullock-carts. Imagine the heat and dust, the sound of children playing, and street-vendors haggling with their customers.

Given the geographical spread of the civilization, it is not surprising that there are regional variations. Nonetheless, there is an extraordinary level of standardization including weights and measures, the characteristic terracotta seals and so on. This has led many commentators to argue that there was a centralized empire that imposed order over the whole system.
Unfortunately, we know nothing about the political structure and, as already mentioned, we have yet to find any building that can be definitely identified as an imperial palace or a political centre. In fact, we know almost nothing for sure about historic events, political leaders, religion and language. The Harappans did have a script but it has not yet been deciphered.

THE MERCHANTS OF MELUHHA

Despite our near-total ignorance about the political history of the civilization, we now know a great deal about its geography. Over the last century, thousands of sites have been found and several new sites are being discovered every year. It appears that the subcontinent was very populous even at this early stage. The core of the Harappan civilization extended over a large area, from Gujarat in the south, across Sindh and Rajasthan and extending into Punjab and Haryana. Numerous sites have been found outside the core area, including some as far east as Uttar Pradesh and as far west as Sutkagen-dor on the Makran coast of Baluchistan, not far from Iran. There is even a site in Central Asia called Shortughai along the Amu Darya, close to the Afghan-Tajik border. Thus, the geographical spread, the number of sites and implied population of the Harappan civilization dwarfs that of contemporary Egypt, China or Mesopotamia. What the Harappans lack in grand buildings, they make up for in the sheer scale of their civilizational reach and in the extraordinary municipal sophistication of their cities.

We also know that the people of the civilization were actively engaged in domestic and international trade. For land transport, the Harappans used bullock-carts that are almost exactly the same as those that can still be seen